

Texas Spotlight: Employment Services Virtual Conference in November 2024

Background

The Texas Workforce Commission (TWC), Texas Education Agency (TEA), and the Texas Health and Human Services Commission (HHSC) have a history of collaborating to support Employment First implementation. These agencies aim to organize the way they work together to accomplish collective projects.

One of these projects is a cross-agency virtual conference. Currently, the Community Services, Policy and Strategy, and Special Projects team at Texas HHSC is leading all three agencies in organizing this conference for November 2024. The goal of the cross-agency virtual conference is for the agencies to improve service coordination, including how and when people receive services. The organizers see this conference as the first of many initiatives to move away from providing services in silos, and to bring the agencies' efforts together around employment and people with disabilities.

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What Happened

The cross-agency virtual conference in November will address the objectives of improving referrals for services, service coordination, and systems for exchange and ongoing collaboration. Organizers are holding biweekly planning sessions for the conference and are considering it to be a possible starting point for follow-up cross-agency virtual presentations.

The conference is scheduled to take place over two days, during which each agency will present for three hours on programs, services, and operations. Presentations will cover the different direct services TWC and TEA offer as well as the HHSC's toolkits, user guides, manuals, and other products available to support service delivery. One planned presentation is an explanation of the role of Texas's local intellectual and developmental disability authorities (LIDDAs) in delivering services. Another presentation will feature the Employment First Discovery tool implemented in the fall of 2023. After the conference, attendees can submit additional questions through a mailbox for presenters to address at possible future webinars or conferences.

The conference organizers hope attendees will gain a broader knowledge of the services all three agencies provide and where items intersect. It is likely that attendees will learn something new about their own agency. Ultimately, the hope is that all attendees can apply the knowledge gained from the conference to effectively coordinate smooth service delivery in the future. Conference organizers particularly hope attendees in the provider sector will be able to more effectively equip individuals with resources to navigate through various systems to support their employment goals.

Questions to Consider

1. What are the strongest agency partnerships in your state? Why do these agencies work together well? What resources does it take to keep this going?
2. What questions or assumptions arise about the services people receive, how they are provided, and who provides them?

For more information, contact **Monty Chamberlain**,
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State Employment Leadership Network

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

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